

IN CONTEXT

Villa Senar

In 1930, Rachmaninoff bought land near Hertenstein on Lake Lucerne in Switzerland, and on it he built a substantial house, designed by the local architects Alfred Möri and Karl-Friedrich Krebs. He called the house Villa Senar (from the first two letters of his and his wife's forenames, Sergei and Natalia, and the first letter of Rachmaninoff).

He spent every summer there until moving permanently to the US in 1939. The villa and the spectacular lake on which it was situated gave Rachmaninoff the tranquility he needed for composing his music. It was here that he wrote two of his greatest works: Rhapsody on a Theme of Paganini (1934) and Symphony No. 3 (1935–1936).